

JONAH

"I'm sure this city will get their punishment from the Lord. No doubt about it. Just wait, Nineveh, you've been doing evil things for too long. If I recall, you've been violent and brutal. No wonder you're called the city of blood. You're also greedy for wealth, as if you're going to take all your riches to your grave. I'm also certain that God is disgusted by your idolatry and sorcery. And on top of it, you're proud of these, and you think of them as a great achievement. May God destroy you and your city that not one stone will be left upon another."

Jonah was greatly upset by the deeds of the people of Nineveh. He even prayed to God, "May Your judgment come quickly upon them, Lord."

The following day, as Jonah was resting, he heard the voice of the Lord commanded him, "Go, Jonah, to the city of Nineveh. Tell them that their wickedness has come to my attention. Warn them that I, the Lord, will execute judgment shortly upon all the inhabitants of the city."

"Go right ahead, Lord. Punish them immediately. They don't need anyone to warn them, do they?"

But the Lord did not answer Jonah. It's obvious that Jonah was to go and warn Nineveh of the impending judgment. Nevertheless, Jonah had in his mind something completely against God's command. Instead of launching to Nineveh, he sailed away to Tarshish on a merchant ship.

The Lord knew Jonah's plan, so He sent a powerful wind to toss the ship. When the ship was about to break up, the captain called everyone and cast lots to find the guilty party. No surprise that Jonah was chosen.

"Who are you? What are you doing here? What have you done that you put us in this situation? Tell us honestly," said the captain of the ship.

"I am the servant of the most high God, the Creator of the sea. I'm trying to escape from Him because He told me to go to another place; that's why I'm here."

"What should we do to you to calm the sea? The Lord is angry to us because of you."

"I know it's my fault. Just throw me into the sea, and the storm will cease."

At first, the crew didn't want to throw Jonah, but the storm grew worse. They could do nothing but to do what Jonah told them to.

"O Lord, don't hold us guilty for sacrificing innocent blood. You have your way, Lord."

They finally threw Jonah into the sea, and immediately the sea stopped raging. As for Jonah, God has prepared a huge fish to swallow him.

"I was drowning into the deep, but you heard me, O Lord.
I was at the brim of death, yet you saved me.
Those who worship idols have turned from your mercy.
But I will be faithful to you.
For you are my salvation."

After Jonah lifted up his prayer from the belly of the fish, he was vomitted on dry land. The Lord said to Jonah the second time, "Go to Nineveh and proclaim the message I told you."

This time Jonah obeyed God and declared in Nineveh for three days the message of the Lord.

"This is the word of the Lord: In forty days, Nineveh will be destroyed!"

This message struck the hearts of the people of Nineveh. Even the king took off his royal robe, put on a sackcloth, and sat in ashes. He issued a proclamation:

"No human or animal is to taste anything. All must put on sackcloth and cry earnestly to God. Everyone must turn from their evil way and repent. May God turn from His anger that we may live."

God did turn away from His wrath and spared Nineveh, Jonah was displeased by this.

"This is why I didn't want to warn them, Lord. You're just too kind as to forgive them. They should be punished!"

Jonah refused to understand why God forgave Nineveh. For Jonah, all evil must be punished and given no room for repentance. But God's mercy is greater than our comfort and feelings, and His love for the people creates a room for a change to bring Him glory."